told somebody else that "all the bad news is out in Hong Kong." Eavesdropping on these experts had the same result as watching them on financial television—the longer I tuned in, the more befuddled I got.

During the formal sessions, the audience wanted to hear hot tips from the speakers, while the speakers preferred to teach their methodology. This reminded me of the adage, "If you give a man a fish, he'll eat today, but if you show him how to fish, he'll eat forever." I regret to report that many of us were looking for a fish, and couldn't have cared less about the fishing lessons. The speakers seemed to understand this, and they deliberately held back their hot tips and best bets—until the end of their lectures. That kept us in our seats.

I was amazed at the forethought and calculation that goes into the picking of stocks. It's gone way beyond just asking the neighbors. In fact, a long-standing doctrinal dispute between two stock-picking camps provoked as much debate as you'd get at any interfaith retreat or ecumenical council. These rival camps are called the Technicians and the Fundamentalists, and both were well represented here. That you shouldn't go near the stock market without choosing sides was one of the few points of universal agreement, and it was news to me. I didn't even know if my stockbroker was Catholic or Jewish.

From what I could gather, the Technicians believe that the best way to foretell the future direction of any market is from the market action itself. Many of them study market action with graphs and charts, so they're also known as Chartists. At the conference, the Chartists could be recognized by the piles of graphs that they'd lug around and hand out to the audience. Those zigzags in the Dow Jones averages that the rest of us take for artwork in the business section, the Chartists study and restudy, to help them predict the next zig or zag.

It doesn't have to be the Dow Jones averages. It could be an individual stock, a pork belly, the interest rates, the Transportation Index, or anything else that can be expressed in wiggles, and a Chartist can interpret it. I saw them do it several times. They'd pull out some graph, take a quick glance at the wavy lines, and